



Dual battle: Indian women's team, under Salima Tete (C), is fighting on two fronts, chasing progress on the pitch while navigating the battles around it. AFP

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A hierarchy, mostly undisturbed

As the Netherlands chases a fourth straight World Cup title on home soil, India's women arrive amid turmoil and low expectations.

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If the rest of the world caught up with Asia before inching ahead in the 21st century in the men's game, the continent has never been the standard-bearer in the women's. No Asian team has won an Olympic gold or a World Cup title in the combined 27 editions of

these tournaments. In fact, in the 15 World Cups, only three times has an Asian team made the semifinals, with China's run in 2002 being the most recent.

The Netherlands is the superpower in the women's game, rattling off successive Olympic golds

and World Cup titles. The rest of the world, including Argentina and Belgium, is trying to close the gap, without much success. China, too, has rediscovered its past glory in recent years and is now in with a shout.

India, meanwhile, has never been